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God's Plans Are Perfect

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God's Plans Are Perfect

Today's Reading: John 18:19-24

Hearing God's Voice for Today:

"When he had said these things, one of the officers standing by struck Jesus with his hand, saying, 'Is that how you answer the high priest?' Jesus answered him, 'If what I said is wrong, bear witness about the wrong; but if what I said is right, why do you strike me?' Annas then sent him bound to Caiaphas."

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Annas was the former high priest—back when Jesus had cleansed the Temple three years earlier. That had embarrassed Annas, so he despised Jesus. He had wanted to exact some revenge, though he didn't have any authority to do so at that time.

Annas asked Jesus about his teaching. Jesus told him to talk with those who had listened to him in the synagogues and Temple. That led one of the nearby guards to strike Jesus. He thought Jesus was being insolent and disrespectful.

The guard's blow was another way Jesus took your punishment for sin upon himself. He endured great injustice because of his great love for you.

But there's another truth here that the Lord wants you to ponder.

There are times when you should not try to defend yourself. Some hours later, when Jesus was before Herod, he refused to respond to him and defend himself. He knew it was useless for him to say anything to Herod.

But with Annas, Jesus did the opposite. There are times when it's necessary to defend yourself—especially when the accusations aren't truthful. The guard thought Jesus to be insolent. But Jesus knew that he'd spoken nothing but the truth. As God's law says in Exodus 22:28: "You shall not revile God, nor curse a ruler of your people." Jesus had not cursed Annas, nor had he reviled God. He was perfectly within his rights to defend himself.

Truthful self-defense is not sinful. If someone is maliciously spreading lies about you, it is perfectly acceptable for you to defend yourself. You can set the record straight. If you don't, who will?

People will revile you because you love Jesus. Lies will be spread about you. The father of lies will work behind the scenes to slander your name. But don't despair. Though they can kill the body, they can't touch your soul. Speak the truth in love. Stand courageously for the Lord. He will give you the words to speak when you need them.

He will do that because his love for you is so great.

Annas then sent Jesus to Caiaphas, who despised him as well. The plot to kill Jesus was inching forward. The plan to make salvation available to the world was advancing as well.

None of the Father's plans can be thwarted. This is true for everything in the world. All human history is God's story.

It's true in your personal life as well. He knew you while you were being formed in your mother's womb. He knew you by name before the world was ever created.

God's purpose for your life is perfect.

No weapon formed against you will prosper.

[from *"Hearing the Voice of God"* by Pastor David Chadwick, Moments of Hope Church, Charlotte, NC]